

GROUND ZERO
Aruna Roy at a Mazdoor Kisan Shakti Sangathan programme in Rajasthan, 1996

RIGHT TO INFORMATION ACT, 2005

Breaching the Babu Barrier

Born from grassroots resilience, this landmark legislation put the might of information in the hands of millions while making the powers that be accountable

BY KAUSHIK DEKA

In the dusty lanes of Devdungri, Rajasthan, a revolution quietly took root. Peasants, led by the fiery resolve of Aruna Roy, Nikhil Dey and Shankar Singh of the Mazdoor Kisan Shakti Sangathan (MKSS), demanded access to muster rolls—mundane employment records that held the secret to systemic corruption. Their demand for transparency soon ballooned into a national movement, culminating in the groundbreaking law, the Right to Information Act (RTI), 2005.

DID YOU KNOW?

The RTI Act of 2005 replaced the earlier Freedom of Information Act, 2002, which was seen as insufficient in promoting transparency and accountability

Pushed by Sonia Gandhi and the National Advisory Council, of which Roy was also a member, this legislation was enacted by the United Progressive Alliance (UPA) government under prime minister Manmohan Singh in 2005. The Act became a cornerstone of India's democratic architecture, granting citizens the legal right to access information from public authorities. By dismantling the pervasive culture of secrecy, a relic of colonial era laws like the Official Secrets Act of 1923, the RTI Act empowered or-